The Moon Path

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 1

Late afternoon lay golden over Explorer Camp. Below the treehouse, a narrow path wound between the roots of an enormous oak. It was a good path for walking. It was a pleasant path for pulling a wagon.

It was becoming a rather alarming path for riding in one.

Nib came bouncing down the hill in a little wooden cart. His red scarf streamed behind him. A picnic basket rattled at his feet, and his goggles kept slipping over his nose.

“Lark! Good news! The Adventure Wagon is very fast!”

Lark swooped out of the oak. She was a teal songbird in a well-used explorer's vest, and she had been having a perfectly quiet afternoon until the wagon arrived.

“And the brakes?”

“That's the other news!”

The wagon struck a root. Nib's sandwich jumped out of the basket. He caught it with one paw while Lark grabbed the handle with both feet.

Ahead lay a very large puddle. Above it hung a very low branch.

“Scarf!”

Nib flung the end of his scarf around the branch. The wagon swung around the tree and stopped with a wooden squeak. Its flag carried on without it, then flopped over Nib's head.

“Excellent brakes.”

Something crinkled beneath a wheel. Lark brushed away the leaves and uncovered a battered explorer's case. Its corners were green with age, but its brass latch still shone.

Nib lifted the flag off one eye.

“Did we find treasure already?”

“We found something.”

Then Lark noticed you beside the path. She moved over, leaving room between herself and Nib.

“Want to open it with us?”

The latch was cool beneath your fingers. You lifted it. The lid sprang up, and a folded sheet of paper popped out, unfolded in the air, and landed squarely on Nib's face.

His nose poked through a hole in the middle.

“I can see where we're going!”

“That's a hole.”

“A very clear map.”

Lark gently unhooked the paper from his nose. She spread it across a stump, smoothing the creases with the edge of one wing.

“I'm Lark. This is Nib. I draw maps.”

“I build things.”

He glanced at the wagon.

“Almost finished things.”

“We could use another explorer.”

You leaned closer. Much of the map was missing. Ragged gaps interrupted its paths, and one whole edge had been torn away. But near the center stood a drawing of a magnificent tree. A tiny door nestled among its roots.

Lark's wing grew still.

“The Treasure Tree.”

“Does it grow treasure?”

“There's a secret room inside it. Nobody at camp has found the way in. My first camp map had this tree on it. I've wanted to find it ever since.”

“What do you think is inside?”

“I don't know yet. That's my favorite part.”

Nib measured the little door with his paws, then measured his tummy.

“I could fit through that. With a small amount of wriggling.”

First, however, they would have to find it. Lark followed the broken trails with a feather. Most ended at empty spaces. One surviving corner showed a lagoon, a patch of woods, and a river dock. Beside the dock was a drawing of a crescent-shaped lantern. A pale stone glimmered inside it.

“A moonstone. Look where its light falls.”

In the picture, a faint trail appeared beneath the lantern's glow. It continued toward the outline of a missing map piece.

“If we find that stone, its light might show us where to look next.”

“Then that's where we start. With the bit we've got.”

Lark looked at him, then folded away the blank planning sheet she had already taken from her satchel.

Together, you followed the surviving path: lagoon, woods, river.

Nib packed the picnic basket. Lark added a coil of rope. Nib added an umbrella and a wooden spoon. Nobody was quite sure about the spoon, but he seemed very certain.

With you beside them, the two explorers set off.

The lagoon shone between tall reeds. Dragonflies hovered over a narrow channel, and the woods waited on the other side. Just beneath the water, you could make out a row of flat stepping platforms.

Nib opened his umbrella and studied it thoughtfully.

“That is not a boat.”

“It could be a very small boat.”

A breeze turned it inside out. Nib folded it without another word.

Beside the channel stood an old trail machine. A moon was carved above its lever. Below the moon sat a small square key bearing a little letter: m.

“The old explorers put letter keys on their trail machines. Each key has a sound. This letter makes a little hum. Listen. Mmm.”

She closed her beak. Nib pressed his lips together and tried the hum too.

“Mmm.”

His goggles trembled down his nose.

“My nose is doing it too.”

“Lips together. Mmm. You can try it with us.”

The little hum hardly disturbed the dragonflies. It was a comfortable sound, tucked behind closed lips.

Lark pointed to the moon above the machine.

“Mmm… moon. Hear that sound at the beginning?”

She pressed the letter key. The machine hummed, and the first platform rose dripping from the water. But the key's retaining clip was loose. With a tiny clink, the key dropped out and landed beside a spare.

One was m. The other was s.

“I think your bridge dropped something.”

“We need the little letter for mmm.”

You examined the two keys. One had a straight stem and two little humps. That was m, the letter Lark had shown you. You fitted it into the empty slot.

The hum returned. One by one, the platforms lifted until a dry path stretched across the channel.

“A bridge you can hear!”

Before crossing, Lark bent the loose clip back into place. Nib gave the key a careful wiggle. It stayed put.

Then the wagon rolled safely over the water.

“I like this boat much better.”

The woods smelled of damp earth and green leaves. A storm had scattered branches across the paths and knocked down the direction signs. One trail marker remained: a moon above three carved pictures. Moss. A mushroom. The river dock.

Lark was studying the pictures when Nib spotted a muddy slope.

“Or… that way.”

It certainly looked shorter. It also swallowed the wagon's front wheel with a deep, satisfied plop.

Nib pulled. The wagon stayed where it was. His goggles slid down.

“The shortcut has become a long cut.”

Lark braced the wagon while Nib looped their rope around the axle. You helped them pull. The wheel came free so suddenly that Nib sat down in the mud.

When he stood, one foot wore an enormous brown boot.

“Let's use the trail clues.”

“You find the way. I'll watch the wheels.”

At the first fork, bare rocks covered one path. Soft green moss carpeted the other.

Lark said both names slowly enough to hear their beginnings.

“Rock. Moss. Mmm… moss. Which one starts with our little hum?”

Moss. You led the way onto the green path. The wagon rolled easily, and Nib bounced once on the springy ground.

“It's a carpet. The woods have a carpet.”

At the next fork, a yellow flower nodded beside one trail. A small mushroom stood beside the other.

“Mushroom. Flower. Listen for mmm at the beginning.”

Mushroom began with the sound you knew. Its path curved around the hill, passed beneath a fallen branch, and opened onto the river.

There, across the shining water, a little ferry waited at an island landing. On its roof hung a crescent lantern. Something pale glowed inside.

“There! That's our treasure!”

He took a triumphant step. His mud boot stayed behind.

Nib looked back at it.

“You can keep that.”

The dock was weathered silver by wind and water. Two bell ropes hung from a post. Beside them stood a copper control panel, streaked with dried mud.

Inside a dry wooden box, you found a book. The ferry on its cover looked exactly like the one across the river.

“A book about our boat.”

Lark settled beside you and opened it. The first picture showed an explorer holding a lantern over a map. Where the light touched the paper, a hidden path appeared.

“The moon ferry carries a special lantern. Its moonstone light can show paths hidden in explorer maps.”

“That's exactly what we need.”

On the next page, a drawing showed the dock's copper panel, then a bell. Lark read the instructions beneath it.

“To call the ferry home, first mend the mark on the dock. Then ring the bell beside the same mark.”

There was the little letter again. A straight stem. Two humps. You had met it at the lagoon.

Nib reached for a bell rope, then stopped.

“Hang on. What comes first? Fix the mark, or ring the bell?”

You looked from the book to the panel. The mark came first. Its copper groove was shaped like m, but the soft material inside had washed away. A break ran through the middle, leaving the bell post dark.

“The groove is still here. We can mend it.”

“I'll get the boat rope ready. And one spare.”

He made a sturdy loop, tested the knot, then made another loop large enough to fit over his own head. He considered it for a moment and wisely set it aside.

Lark brushed the mud from the copper groove. A small pot of soft repair paste hung beside it, with a broad-tipped tool tucked into the handle. Nib stirred the paste with his wooden spoon, looking pleased that he had packed it after all. Then he passed you the tool.

“Start at the top. Down. Back up and over, down. Up and over, down.”

You can follow that little m in the air with your finger, if you like. One downstroke. Then two rounded humps, each coming down to the bottom.

At the dock, you worked slowly along the wide groove. Lark steadied the paste pot. Nib kept the rope out of the water. The first stem filled. Then the first hump. Then the second.

A thread of light ran through the repaired letter, along the copper strip, and all the way to the bell post.

“Look! It goes all the way to the bell.”

Lark checked the book once more. First, mend the mark. Done. Next, ring the matching bell.

She gave the rope beneath m a gentle pull. A low, humming note traveled over the water. The ferry's little paddle began to turn, and the boat glided away from the island.

Nib caught its bow with his rope and pulled it alongside the dock.

“Hello, treasure.”

He stepped aboard and lifted the lantern from its hook. Its light shone through his whiskers.

Behind him, the boarding rope slipped off a short post.

The dock began moving away.

No. The dock was staying exactly where it was.

“Lark?”

“I see it.”

“The boat is doing a leaving.”

The ferry drifted into a lazy circle of current. A thick bed of reeds waited beyond it, and Nib was safely in the middle of the boat, but he would much rather have been in the middle of the dock.

He opened the umbrella and tried to paddle.

It turned inside out.

“Still not a boat.”

This time, however, he found a job for it. He folded the umbrella around the lantern and nestled the bundle between his feet.

Lark flew to a low branch. She could reach Nib, but a mouse and a lantern were far too heavy for one small songbird to carry.

“Keep the stone safe. We can call you back.”

“I've got the rope. I've got the lantern. Ready when you are.”

Lark returned to the dock. The copper repair still glowed. Both bell ropes hung within reach: one beneath s, and one beneath m.

You knew what the book had said. Ring the bell beside the same mark.

“Which little letter makes mmm?”

You found the straight stem and two humps. The little m. You took its rope and pulled.

The low note sounded again. A shiver passed through the ferry. Its paddle dipped into the river, turned, and brought the bow around toward home.

Nib sat up so quickly that his goggles tipped sideways.

“I'm doing a coming back!”

As the ferry drew near, he threw his spare loop. Lark caught it and slipped it over a broad dock post. Nib pulled from his end until the boat rested snugly against the wood.

“Rope on!”

“Boat stopped!”

He stepped ashore, checked the lantern, and let out a long breath.

“Treasure found. Mouse delivered.”

For a moment, nobody hurried. Water tapped softly beneath the dock. Nib unwound the umbrella from the lantern and gave you a small, sincere wave.

Lark settled beside you.

“A little letter did a big job.”

Evening was turning the river blue when the lantern opened. Inside rested a smooth, pale stone, small enough to fit in Nib's cupped paws.

“It's smaller than I thought.”

“Try its light on the map.”

You unfolded the torn paper and moved the moonstone above it. At first, nothing changed. Then a pale dot appeared. Another followed. A whole trail emerged beneath the glow, curving past the river toward a cluster of fruit trees.

An orchard.

Beside it shone the outline of another map piece.

“There! That's where we go next.”

Nib followed the new trail with a paw until it reached the torn edge.

“And after the orchard?”

“We'll find out when we get that piece.”

“One adventure at a time.”

You tilted the moonstone. Another faint drawing appeared in the margin: an explorer holding an extremely large sandwich.

Nib stared.

“It understands me.”

Lark opened a small treasure case. Inside was a soft-lined compartment, just the right size for the moonstone.

“Our first treasure belongs in your collection. We can take it out when we need its light.”

You settled the stone into its place. Nib laid his sandwich beside it.

Lark looked at the sandwich. Then she looked at Nib.

“That goes in the picnic basket.”

“Different kinds of treasure.”

By the time you reached camp, the treehouse windows glowed among the leaves. Nib parked the Adventure Wagon and wedged a large rock behind each wheel. Lark brought out the crew's journal.

On its first page, she had drawn the battered case, the torn map, and a small mouse with his nose poking through the middle.

“One adventure. One chapter.”

“Did you put the rescue in?”

“All of it.”

“Even the umbrella?”

“Especially the umbrella.”

You sat together beneath the treehouse lamp while Lark read. There was the lagoon, with its humming bridge. There were the mossy path and the little mushroom. There was the book that showed you what to do, and the broken mark you had mended together.

When she reached the picture of m, Lark paused.

“And it made this sound… mmm.”

The next picture showed Nib on the ferry, one paw holding the rope and the other resting on the bundled lantern.

“The umbrella helped very little.”

On the last page, a moonlit trail led into an orchard. Beyond it, Lark had left the paper blank.

There would be more journeys to put there. More pieces of the map to find. More chapters to read again.

For now, your first adventure was safe between the covers. Lark placed the journal on the camp library shelf.

“I'll bring the map next time.”

“I'll bring the wagon.”

He proudly showed you his new brake: an enormous cushion tied across the wagon's front.

Lark studied it.

“Those are your brakes?”

“Very comfortable brakes.”

Something small rustled down the path. An apple rolled out of the dusk, bumped against the wagon wheel, and stopped beside Nib's foot.

He picked it up. You all looked toward the distant orchard.

“Oh. The next adventure sent a snack.”

Above the treehouse, the first star appeared. On the library shelf, a new book waited. And inside the little treasure case, the moonstone shone softly, ready for whatever came next.

The Apple Catcher

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 2

The apple was still beside the wagon wheel. It had rolled into camp after your moonstone adventure, and Nib had been guarding it very carefully. This morning, it had one small bite missing.

“An investigation,” Nib explained solemnly. “I had to find out whether it was an apple.”

Lark spread your surviving map on the explorer case. In the moonstone’s amber light, the orchard line appeared again. She packed the map, stone, journal, rope, and umbrella. Nib added the apple.

As the wagon passed the camp oak, a wheel bumped its crooked root. “That tree has its foot out,” Nib complained mildly. Lark helped him steer around it. Then you followed the apple’s clue.

At the fork, Lark checked the little mark copied from your first adventure. You had met its closed-lip hum beside the lagoon. The new orchard clue could wait while you remembered the old one.

“Which little letter makes our hum?” Lark asked gently.

The orchard smelled of apples and damp leaves. A wooden chute sloped between two trees. Beneath it hung a catching cloth, but one corner had come loose. Fallen apples were heaped beside an old box on a low shelf.

Three more apples waited behind a wooden stop at the top of the chute. Nothing was moving now.

“I am an excellent apple basket,” Nib declared proudly. He spread his little arms. One apple filled them.

“You are a rather small one,” Lark observed gently. “Let’s mend the catcher before we release the next apples. We must keep that old box safe.”

A carved apple marked the brass catch. Beside it was a little letter with a round middle and a short stem: lowercase a. The other catch carried the m you knew.

“Listen at the beginning of apple,” Lark invited softly. “Apple. Ant. That open little sound is the sound for this a. Listen.”

Nib put his apple in the wagon, then stretched the cloth toward the post while Lark held the frame steady. The loose corner would reach the catch if you chose its new little letter.

“Find the little letter for the start of apple,” Lark encouraged warmly.

The corner caught, but its fastening loop still dangled. Without that loop, a heavy apple could pull the cloth free again. Two wooden picture marks showed where the loop might go.

Lark named them aloud: ant and moon. Nib kept both paws on the cloth. The waiting apples stayed behind their stop.

“Which picture starts with the same little sound as apple?” Lark asked clearly. “Then fasten the loop before you let an apple down.”

The loop held. You lifted the wooden stop, and an apple rolled down the chute into the cloth. It settled with a soft, comfortable thump. The old route box stayed safe on its shelf.

“Caught!” Nib exclaimed delightedly. He clapped so hard that his empty pockets flapped.

Lark and Nib gathered the apples from around the shelf. They put several in the picnic basket. Now the path to the box was clear, and the next apples had somewhere safe to land.

Lark opened the journal on a flat board. She placed the new a beside your familiar m. Two little letters could do something new together.

“Start with the open sound from apple,” Lark explained patiently. “Then close your lips into our hum. Keep them close together: am.”

“I am an apple catcher,” Nib announced proudly. “A catcher who also enjoys a snack.”

Lark pointed beneath the two letters. “Slide with me, then say am if you like,” Lark invited gently. “I’ll read the rest of our sentence.”

The old box had a little brass lift latch and an apple carved into its lid. It was dry and undented. Nib stood beside the shelf while Lark laid your surviving map on a flat board.

“We can open it safely now,” Lark murmured eagerly. “Lift the latch. Then see where the paper inside belongs.”

Inside lay a folded map section and an illustrated note. Lark read it aloud. Earlier explorers had kept pieces of their worn map in route boxes, so each part would stay safe until someone came along the path.

Your original section had four empty spaces beside it. The orchard piece fitted one. Two sections together now; three spaces still waiting.

Lark passed the moonstone above the joined paper. A hidden line appeared, leading through a windy hollow to a little roofed waystation on the ridge.

“Another small clue,” Lark remarked thoughtfully. “Enough for our next adventure.”

Nib drew the catcher in the journal. In his picture, every pocket held an apple. Lark wrote their new little word in the sentence, and you could join its two sounds again whenever you wished.

They tucked the first missing section into the case beside the original map. The moonstone and journal went with it. The empty route box closed neatly on its shelf.

“I am an apple catcher,” Nib repeated contentedly. He tossed his saved apple a little way up and caught it himself.

The catcher rested between the trees, fastened and ready. Your basket held apples for the road, and the ridge route was safe inside the case. The orchard’s little problem was solved.

A gust ran through the branches. The wagon’s small pennant fluttered. Nib looked from the pennant to the folded picnic cloth, then toward the windy hollow.

“I have an idea,” Nib whispered excitedly. Lark tucked the map away before the breeze could catch it. Together, you turned the wagon toward the ridge.

The Sail That Wouldn't Stay

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 3

The picnic cloth lay across the wagon. The apple catcher was behind you, and the first missing map section rested safely beside your original piece. The moonstone, rope, and journal were packed in the explorer case. Three spaces on the map were still empty.

A breeze slipped through the hollow. The wagon’s pennant fluttered, and Nib’s idea grew taller than his ears.

“A sail the size of the sky!” Nib announced grandly.

He tied the picnic cloth to a light wooden mast while Lark set chocks beside the wheels. The wagon stayed parked on the broad, dry path. The cloth swelled above it like a very ambitious pillow.

“A wagon the size of a mouse,” Lark replied cautiously. She held the rope and watched the cloth pull sideways.

Nib opened the journal to the apple page. He pointed to the little word you had joined before.

“I am a sailor,” Nib declared hopefully.

“I’ll read the other words,” Lark offered warmly. “You can read am. Slide its two sounds, or join them with me.”

The breeze grew stronger. Grass brushed against the wagon with a soft hiss. The wheels stayed snug beside their chocks, but the enormous sail tugged toward the side of the path.

Nib gripped his scarf. He looked at the rope, then at Lark.

“Perhaps the sky is a little large,” Nib admitted doubtfully.

“We can make a smaller plan,” Lark replied calmly. She eased the rope until the cloth stopped pulling. Nobody climbed aboard.

On the journal’s empty page, Lark drew a little curving letter. It bent one way, then the other: lowercase s.

“Listen to the grass,” Lark invited softly. “Let a gentle stream of air make our soft hiss. No hum, and no extra little vowel. Listen to the sound, then find its letter.”

Nib held the page flat on the explorer case. Lark drew the curving mark once more, slowly enough to follow.

“It looks as if it knows a bend in the path,” Nib observed thoughtfully.

“We’ll keep it beside today’s picture,” Lark suggested gently. “Curve round, then curve back. Write our new s.”

Beside the path, a low supply shelter held a folded mat and an empty cloth sack. A shallow patch of dry sand lay nearby. Lark named both objects aloud. Mat. Sack.

Nib considered sitting on the mat until the wind changed its mind. Then he looked at the empty sack, the sand, and the wagon’s low frame.

“Something small could help something tall,” Nib murmured hopefully.

“Let’s begin with the sound,” Lark invited warmly. “Mat. Sack. Which one starts with the soft hiss we just learned?”

Lark brought the sack to a flat spot beside the wagon. She folded its top outward so the opening stayed wide. A stitched line showed how much sand it needed. The sack would rest low against the frame, with a rope loop to hold it.

Nib scooped a little sand into it. The base spread into a soft, sturdy shape.

“A sensible sack,” Nib declared approvingly. “It knows where the ground is.”

“Fill it just to the stitched line,” Lark encouraged gently. “Then I’ll secure its loop. The wagon will keep waiting while we work.”

The filled sack settled low beside the explorer case. Lark fastened its loop to the wagon’s frame. Nib folded the enormous cloth down and tied it into a small sail. Every fold made the mast look less surprised.

The next breeze pressed against the little triangle. Lark tested the rope. The sack stayed low. The wheels stayed level. The small sail helped without pulling the parked wagon sideways.

Nib studied his first enormous plan, now folded into something useful.

“Still splendid,” Nib decided contentedly. “Just less sky.”

Lark showed the two versions in the journal: the great billowing cloth, and the small folded sail beside the low sand sack.

“Which sail helped our wagon stay steady?” Lark asked gently.

With the test finished, Lark removed the chocks. Nib took the handle while Lark guided the rope. Together, they brought the wagon up the broad path. The little sail helped when the breeze followed them. When it did not, your friends simply pulled.

At the ridge waystation, they parked beneath the shelter and set the chocks beside the wheels again. The case was safe. The first map piece was safe. Nothing new had been added to the map.

Lark drew the little sail and the sand sack on your next journal page. Your new s curled beside the picture. She read the connecting words aloud, and you could join am again whenever you wanted.

“Small sail. Sensible sack. Splendid sailing,” Nib murmured with satisfaction.

A soft tapping came from beneath the roof. Nib put one paw on the little table. Its far end rose a tiny way, then settled with another tap.

“That table has an idea, too,” Nib whispered suspiciously.

Lark smiled and set the journal safely on the flat floor. The wagon was steady, the windy hollow was behind you, and the tapping table could wait for your next adventure.

The Tipping Table

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 4

The wagon rested beneath the ridge shelter. Its small sail was folded, its wheels were chocked, and its sand sack sat low beside the explorer case. Inside the case lay your original map and the first missing section. Three spaces still waited to be filled.

Something tapped beneath the shelter roof. Nib put one paw on a little timber table. The far corner rose. When he lifted his paw, it dropped with another tap.

“An excellent table, apart from its standing-up,” Nib observed thoughtfully.

Through a small opening above the drawer, Lark could see a folded piece of explorer paper. She tried the handle. The drawer moved a tiny way, then caught.

Nib rolled an apple beneath the short leg. The apple rolled out again.

“A delicious table leg,” Nib murmured doubtfully. “Very poor at staying.”

Lark held the frame steady. On a repair shelf behind her lay several flat wooden offcuts. Beneath the picnic basket was your rolled mat. There were useful things here, if they could work out what to do first.

Lark opened the journal to yesterday's curving letter.

“Here is our soft hiss,” Lark invited gently. “Find s beside m. You can hear either sound again if you want.”

The table answered with a little tap. Lark drew a tall line on the empty page and crossed it near the top.

“This is lowercase t,” Lark explained clearly. “Put your tongue just behind your top teeth. Release a tiny tap of air: /t/. It stops quickly. We won't add an extra vowel. Listen, then find t.”

Nib tried the sound. His goggles slipped. He pushed them up without touching the table.

“A very small sound for a very talkative table,” Nib whispered suspiciously.

Lark set a beside t. She joined their sounds slowly into at. Then she put m at the beginning: m, a, t. Mat.

“Our mat could help,” Lark suggested hopefully. “Read at with me. Now join all three sounds in mat.”

Nib fetched the rolled mat and spread it on the shelter floor. Its corner was soft enough to fold, but firm enough to hold its shape.

Before they used it, Lark left room beside its label in the journal.

“Write t here,” Lark invited warmly. “Down from the top, then a short line across. You can follow my first mark or make your own beside it.”

Nib folded one edge of the mat into a small pad. Lark kept her wing against the tabletop. The gap beneath the short leg remained plainly visible.

“We need to fill that gap before pulling the drawer,” Lark explained calmly. “Put the folded edge beneath the short leg. I'll keep holding the table.”

The pad fitted. Nib pressed one corner of the table, then the other. Both stayed level. This time, when he pulled the drawer, it slid out with a gentle wooden sigh.

Inside lay the second missing section of your map.

“Not even a wobble,” Nib whispered suspiciously. He tapped the tabletop once more, just to make sure.

Lark laid the new paper beside the original and the orchard section. Under the moonstone's amber light, hidden ink drew a route down toward the river. A little island shelter waited at its end. Two spaces remained empty.

A tiny sketch of the Treasure Tree stood in the margin. Its upper branch divided into a fork.

“That branch looks familiar,” Lark murmured thoughtfully. She copied it into the journal before packing the fragile paper.

Nib sat on the unfolded part of the mat. Lark made another word by replacing the first letter of mat with s. Sat.

“Mat. Sat,” Lark read softly. “The same ending, with a different beginning. Try sat with me.”

On your new journal page, she drew the short leg, the folded pad, and the open drawer.

“What let the drawer slide?” Lark asked gently. “Was it pulling harder, or supporting the short leg? You can use our picture to explain.”

Lark held the table while Nib exchanged the temporary mat pad for a flat offcut from the repair shelf. The table stayed steady. Your mat could come with you.

Outside, the first raindrop spotted the path. Nib looked from the cloud to the old map's fraying edge.

“An excellent time,” Nib remarked cautiously, “for paper to have a roof.”

The table was fixed, the second section was safe, and your next route led toward the river.

A Pocket for the Map

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 5

Rain pattered softly on the riverbank. The ferry waited at its dock, tied by a stout rope. Your wagon stood on dry ground beside it. Inside the explorer case were the original map and two recovered sections. The newest line pointed toward the ferry's little island.

Lark opened the umbrella before opening the case. Its broad roof sheltered every scrap of paper.

“The map can wait here while we make a cover,” Lark explained calmly.

Nib was already drawing a plan. It had wheels, seven poles, a roof, and a little shelf for a snack.

“A portable palace for precious paper,” Nib proclaimed enthusiastically.

Lark looked at his drawing. Then she looked at the ferry.

“Could our palace fit in a pocket?” Lark asked hopefully.

Nib added a very large pocket to his picture. Then he rubbed it out.

“Perhaps we should begin with the paper,” Nib conceded thoughtfully.

They unrolled the picnic mat beneath the umbrella. Lark showed you its familiar label without reading it first.

“Try this word,” Lark invited gently. “Look right through to the last letter. You can join the sounds or ask me to help.”

The mat made a dry work surface. Nib laid spare weatherproof cloth across it, with two stiff backing boards from the packing kit. Small pegs and fastening clips rattled in a tin beside his paws.

Lark touched her lips together, then released one little puff of air.

“Listen: /p/,” Lark modeled clearly. “This is lowercase p. Lips together, then a small pop. No extra vowel. Paper and pocket begin with that sound. Find p beside t.”

Nib folded the cloth around one backing board. He tested the fold with a peg. It stayed closed without needing even one palace tower.

Lark laid out m, a, and t. She moved the last letter away and put p in its place.

“Mat ended with /t/,” Lark explained softly. “Now listen all the way through: /m/, /a/, /p/. Map. Join our new word with me.”

Nib made a second flat cover for the picnic mat. The covers had the same cloth, the same shape, and the same little fastenings. One would hold the map on its backing. The other would carry the mat.

“Very good pockets,” Nib declared proudly. “A little difficult to tell apart.”

Lark wrote a label on each. She left a practice space in the journal, too.

“Write p beside our pocket drawing,” Lark invited warmly. “A line down, then a little round part beside its top. You can trace my first one if you want.”

The new letter stood beside the picture. Nib lifted the two covers by their edges. Their labels faced you: map and mat.

“We need the cover for our paper,” Lark reminded you gently. “Read both words. Which one says map?”

Lark kept the paper sheltered while Nib slid it onto its backing in the chosen cover. The matching mat cover stayed beside it. No corner had to bend to fit.

One peg remained open at the last fold.

“I'll keep the paper flat,” Lark offered calmly. “Nib will hold the cover. Put this peg on the little clasp so our fold stays closed.”

The peg gripped the cloth. Nib pressed the fold once, lightly, as if tucking a blanket around a sleeping map.

Lark caught a raindrop on the umbrella's edge and let it fall onto the outside of the folio. The drop shone, rolled, and slipped away. When she checked inside, the paper was dry.

“Perfectly dry,” Nib murmured proudly. “And considerably smaller than a palace.”

Lark drew the two labeled folios in the journal.

“Why did we give the paper a cover?” Lark asked gently. “What might the rain have done if the old map were left out?”

The shower thinned to a few bright drops. You could see the island shelter beyond the reeds. Lark packed the map folio safely in the case. Nib put the mat in its own matching cover and returned the spare pegs and clips to the kit.

Then he slipped an apple into an ordinary pocket.

“Paper pocket. Picnic pocket,” Nib counted contentedly. “An orderly expedition.”

The ferry stayed tied beside the bank. Your map was protected, your supplies were packed, and the island could wait until everyone was ready to travel.

The Little Ink Box

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 6

Nib checked the ferry rope. He checked where it met the post. Then he gave the knot a small, thoughtful tug.

“Rope on. Mouse remaining,” Nib declared firmly.

Your map was dry inside its folio. The original section and two recovered pieces rested on their stiff backing. Lark carried the explorer case aboard while Nib settled the wagon on the deck. Nobody untied the rope until everyone was ready.

The ferry crossed quietly to the island. This time Nib stayed beside the rail. At the island landing, Lark looped the rope over a broad post before anyone stepped onto the dry bank.

Under a low shelter stood the little ink box shown on your map. Its lid was shut. Beside it were a sturdy bench and a brass tapping plate. A rod joined the bench to a small counterweight beneath the box.

Nib tried the handle. The lid stayed closed.

“Very determined ink,” Nib observed cautiously.

Lark brushed dust from an instruction strip. An old black drip spread across its edge. She leaned closer, then sighed.

“I think the ink has hidden the clue,” Lark admitted ruefully.

Nib peered beneath the drip. Two little words stood clear. An arrow ran between them.

“It left the sitting bit,” Nib observed with interest.

Lark took out the journal's practice strip. First she showed a familiar word from your map-pocket adventure.

“Try this one before we look at the new clue,” Lark invited gently. “Read tap. You can take its sounds slowly.”

She drew a short line and put a dot above it.

“Here is lowercase i,” Lark explained clearly. “It makes the short sound at the start of ink: /i/. A quick, relaxed sound. Listen to short a, then short i. Find i beside a.”

Nib kept his paws on the dry bench while Lark set s and t on either side of the new letter. She joined the sounds into sit. Then she changed i to a, making sat.

“The outside letters stay the same,” Lark explained softly. “Listen to the middle. Sit. Sat. Join sit with me, then try the other word.”

The bench looked increasingly inviting to Nib.

“A promising instruction,” Nib murmured hopefully.

Before they tested it, Lark opened the ink-box journal page.

“Write our little i here,” Lark invited warmly. “A short line down, then lift your finger and add its dot. Keep it beside our picture of the ink drip.”

On the real instruction strip, the first word stood above the bench. The second stood above the brass plate. The arrow showed their order.

“Read the two words from left to right,” Lark encouraged gently. “Which job comes first?”

Nib followed the first instruction. He sat on the bench. It lowered a small, safe distance on its pivot. Beneath the box, the counterweight rose into place. The brass plate moved free of its stop.

“Now read the next word,” Lark invited softly. “Use its instruction on the plate.”

With a small tap, the catch clicked. The lid lifted on its hinge and stayed braced above the box.

Inside lay the third missing map section, wrapped in dry cloth. Beside it was a little ink stamp for the journal.

“A splendid box,” Nib declared appreciatively. “It understands sitting down.”

Lark added the new section beside the others. The moonstone revealed a narrow path toward a meadow, with a nest drawn beside the bank. Only one space in the old map remained empty.

She pressed the stamp onto your ink-box page and drew the bench beneath it.

“What made the catch ready for our tap?” Lark asked gently. “Think about the empty bench and the bench after Nib sat down.”

Lark looked again at the old drip. It had covered part of the strip, but not the words they needed.

“Thank you for looking underneath,” Lark told Nib warmly. “I nearly stopped looking.”

Nib rose. The bench returned to its resting place. Lark packed the paper and stamp, and everyone boarded the ferry before the island rope came loose. Back at the ordinary dock, they tied it safely again.

Ahead waited the dry nesting bank. Behind you, the little box was closed, the island was quiet, and all four of your map sections were safe.

The Noisy Wagon

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 7

The ferry was tied behind you. Ahead, a dry bank curved toward the meadow on your newest map section. Nib pulled the wagon slowly along it. The protected map, mat, journal, and explorer case rode safely inside.

A little clatter followed every turn of the wheel.

Nib stopped. The clatter stopped.

He took one more step. Clatter.

On a fixed branch beyond the path rested a nest. A small bird slept inside, its beak tucked into its feathers.

Nib lifted one paw and began an extremely careful tiptoe. The wagon answered with an extremely ordinary rattle.

“I am being exceptionally quiet,” Nib whispered earnestly.

“Your wagon has another opinion,” Lark murmured gently.

She looked beneath the handle. A metal fitting was still attached to the frame, but its free edge knocked against the wood. Nib's feet were not the problem. The fitting needed a fastener.

Lark parked the wagon before the nest. There was room to work without touching the branch.

“We can mend the rattle here,” Lark explained softly. “Then the wagon can be quiet, too.”

First she opened the journal to your ink-box page. She showed sit, then sat.

“Listen to the middle of sit,” Lark invited gently. “Which of these two words has our short i? You can sound them out.”

Nib nudged his nose toward the tool kit. Two matching pockets were closed inside it. Their labels had three little letters each.

Lark drew a line down, another up, and a small arch back down beside it.

“This is lowercase n,” Lark explained clearly. “Put your tongue just behind your top teeth and let your voice hum through your nose: /n/. For m, your lips close. For n, your tongue goes up. Listen to both, then find n.”

“Nest. Nap. Nib,” Nib counted quietly. “A useful beginning.”

Lark placed i beside n. She slid their sounds together into in. With p at the beginning, the word grew into pin.

“In. Pin,” Lark modeled softly. “Join the two sounds, then all three. Our little fastener has a name we can read.”

Nib held the loose fitting against the frame. It stayed quiet beneath his paw, but he could not walk while holding it there.

Lark drew the wagon on a fresh journal page, leaving room for its new letter.

“Write n beside the wheel,” Lark invited warmly. “Down, back up, and over one little arch. You can follow my first mark.”

The two tool pockets faced you. One said pin. The other said tin. Neither was larger or brighter than its neighbor.

“Which pocket has the fastener we need?” Lark asked gently. “Read the beginning as well as the ending. You can ask for a sound if you need one.”

Inside the pin pocket were the small fastening clips packed with your folios. Lark brought one to the fitting. Nib kept the metal edge still.

“The opening is here,” Lark explained calmly. “Clip the fitting to the frame while Nib holds it.”

The clip closed with a little settling click. Nib lifted his paw. The fitting stayed against the wood.

Lark rolled the wagon a short way. Its wheel turned. The case rode smoothly. No clatter followed.

“Now we are both being quiet,” Nib breathed proudly.

The crew passed the nest on the dry path. The bird shifted its feathers, settled more comfortably, and stayed asleep. Nobody needed to touch the nest or creep beneath it.

At the meadow edge, Lark drew Nib tiptoeing beside a wagon with its fitting held tight.

“What stopped the rattle?” Lark asked gently. “Did we change Nib's feet, or did we fasten the loose metal?”

Nib inspected the portrait.

“A remarkably quiet drawing,” Nib whispered approvingly.

The pin stayed on the wagon. Spare clips returned to the kit. Your map still had one empty space, and the meadow was bright ahead.

A red ribbon fluttered from an old post between two animal carvings. This time Nib let the wagon roll to a quiet stop before he hurried to investigate.

The Red Ribbon

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 8

A red ribbon rustled on a meadow post. Beneath it hung a folded note. On one side stood a carved ram with magnificent curved horns. On the other stood a small wooden rat with a round nose.

The wagon was quiet now. Its new pin held the loose fitting against the frame. Your original map and three recovered sections rested safely in their folio. Only the final gap remained.

“The ram! Magnificent horns!” Nib exclaimed eagerly.

He took two steps toward it before Lark fluttered to the post.

“Magnificent,” Lark agreed warmly. “But what does the note say?”

Nib came back. The ribbon marked the place where a clue had been left. It did not point toward either animal. Both carvings had a little drawer beneath their feet.

Lark laid the unopened note on the explorer case. Before reading it, she showed you the label on your map folio.

“Try our familiar word first,” Lark invited gently. “Read it right through. What is the last sound in map?”

The folio stayed closed while Lark drew a short line in the journal with a little shoulder near its top.

“This is lowercase r,” Lark explained clearly. “Listen to the start of red and ribbon: /r/. Let your voice begin smoothly. Keep your tongue from tapping or rolling, and don't add an extra vowel. Find r beside m.”

The ribbon moved in a soft breeze. Nib steadied the case so the paper could not flutter away.

Lark placed r beside a and m. She joined all three sounds into ram.

“Ram,” Lark modeled warmly. “Read the whole word with me. The beginning is /r/. The ending is our closed-lip hum.”

Nib glanced fondly at the horns.

“A very well-dressed word,” Nib observed appreciatively.

Lark opened the note. Its first two letters matched ram. Its last letter did not.

Nib leaned forward, then stopped himself.

“I nearly chose before the end,” Nib admitted thoughtfully.

“We have time for the last sound,” Lark reminded him gently.

Before making the choice, she left space beside the ribbon drawing in your journal.

“Write r here,” Lark invited softly. “Down, back toward the top, and over its small shoulder. You can use my mark to help.”

The note lay open between the carvings. Its word was rat.

“This word tells us which carving to use,” Lark encouraged gently. “Try it yourself. You can speak the sounds, join them quietly, or ask for help. Then choose the animal it names.”

The final t changed the destination. At the rat's base, Lark lifted the ordinary little latch. Nib slid the drawer open. Inside lay the fourth and last missing section of your map.

“Small nose. Excellent drawer,” Nib declared delightedly.

Lark set the new section on its backing beside the others. There was the original, the orchard piece, the ridge piece, the island piece, and this final folded piece. Nothing more needed to be found.

In the moonstone's light, a faint route ran toward a drawing of a crooked root. A folded edge hid the rest.

The wind lifted a corner of the note. Lark caught it before the old paper could bend.

“Let's join everything under shelter,” Lark suggested carefully.

Nib looked at the fragile pieces and nodded.

“A grand discovery,” Nib murmured sensibly, “deserves somewhere flat.”

Lark untied the ribbon and tucked it into the journal. It would be useful when your loose adventure pages were ready to become a book.

On today's page she drew both animals, the little clue, and the opened rat drawer.

“Why did the rat lead us to the paper?” Lark asked gently. “Was it the most splendid carving, or did its name match every sound in our note?”

Nib stood beside the picture of the ram for a moment.

“Fine horns,” Nib told it sincerely. “We simply had different business.”

The last piece was safe. Eight journal pages rested together. Ahead was a sheltered clearing where all five sections could finally meet.

The Map That Came Home

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 9

For the first time, nothing was missing from the explorer case. The original map and all four recovered sections lay inside. Nib counted them twice, using the tip of one careful paw.

“A whole map,” Nib declared hopefully. “Some assembly required.”

The clearing was broad and dry. Nib braced the umbrella over the work spot. Lark fixed the little sail as a windbreak, with the sand sack holding its support low against the ground. They had brought their shelter with them in pieces, too.

Two matching folios rested in the wagon. Their labels faced outward.

“Read the word on the paper cover,” Lark invited gently. “Choose map rather than mat. Look all the way to the last letter.”

Lark spread the picnic mat herself. It made a soft, flat surface under the umbrella. Then she opened the chosen folio and laid its stiff backing on top.

The orchard section met the original. The ridge section continued its path. The island section joined neatly beside it. Each little road led into the next.

The meadow piece did not.

Lark turned it one way, then the other. Its edge was too short. A path ended in empty space.

“Perhaps there is one more piece,” Lark whispered anxiously.

Nib leaned close. Along one edge, the paper looked twice as thick.

“Perhaps there is one more fold,” Nib suggested carefully.

Lark stopped moving it. On the underside, a small flap had been tucked back along an old crease. No new cache was needed. The last connection was hiding against the paper they already had.

“Let's look at that doubled edge,” Lark invited gently. “Open the fold slowly, so we can see the whole drawing.”

The flap unfolded. Its little road continued the island path and curved around the crooked root. The edges fitted.

Nib let out a breath that made his scarf move.

“A very small fold,” Nib murmured appreciatively. “A very large difference.”

Lark brought the tool kit. Two pockets had familiar labels, pin and pan.

“We need the little clips,” Lark reminded you softly. “Read both pocket labels. Which one tells us where to find them? Listen to the middle if you need help.”

She used the spare clips to hold the edges against the stiff backing. No clip pressed on a fragile line. The joined paper stayed flat when Nib moved his paws away.

The moonstone rested in Lark's wing. Its amber light spread across the complete map. Hidden ink appeared along one continuous route: orchard, ridge, river, island, meadow.

Then the line curved back to a treehouse.

Lark stared.

“We came all this way to come home?” Lark asked, bewildered.

Nib turned the drawing until its crooked root pointed toward the oak in your first journal picture. Above the root, the branch divided in two.

“Perhaps we have not looked at all of home,” Nib murmured thoughtfully.

Lark opened the journal beside the map. The oak at camp was drawn from the front. The tree on the map was drawn from behind. The root and forked branch were the same shapes seen from different sides.

“Which tree in our journal has both these features?” Lark asked gently. “Use the root and the branch together. What does that tell us about where the route ends?”

The familiar tree suddenly seemed full of unfamiliar possibilities.

Lark drew the unfolded corner on your ninth page. Beside it she left space for a useful old word.

“Write map beside today's picture,” Lark invited warmly. “You can use our folio label to help with m, a, and p.”

Nib folded the sail and umbrella. The sand sack returned low in the wagon, the mat went into its own folio, and the complete map traveled flat on its backing. This time all its roads stayed together.

By evening, the wagon rested beneath the camp oak. Your treehouse stood above the familiar front steps. Beyond the crooked root, a narrow ground-level path curved around the trunk.

Lark looked along it, then closed the case carefully.

“Our map is finished,” Lark breathed wonderingly. “Tomorrow we can look at the other side.”

Nib settled beside the wheel.

“Home,” Nib murmured contentedly. “With a remarkably promising back.”

The Door in the Tree

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 10

The path around your own oak was narrower than the front path, but just as dry. Nib brought the explorer case. Lark carried the complete map on its backing. Above you, the treehouse roof peeped between the same old branches.

At the rear of the trunk, a crooked root reached over a curtain of vines. High above it, the great branch divided into a fork. Both matched the finished map.

Lark brushed the vines aside. A narrow seam ran through the bark beneath the root.

“It has been our tree all along,” Lark breathed in astonishment.

Nib looked up toward the comfortable front steps.

“We were living on the roof of the treasure,” Nib exclaimed.

Between the roots was a little brass flap. Three familiar letters shone on its front. Lark moved aside so you could see them.

“Try the instruction yourself,” Lark invited gently. “Read its whole word. If you want help, we'll join the sounds together.”

The word was tap. Nib followed your reading with a light tap on the flap. An ordinary catch clicked, and a shallow drawer slid forward. Another little word marked its front.

Lark set the matching folios on the dry ground. One held the picnic mat. The other held the joined paper.

“Which cover matches the drawer's word?” Lark asked softly. “Read map and mat right through to their different endings.”

Nib kept his paws beside the case while you considered the labels. He did not reach for the first one that looked familiar.

“I am waiting for the little sound at the end,” Nib explained proudly.

Lark took the completed map from its folio and slid its stiff backing into the shallow drawer. Above it was a small fitted lamp cup. She set the moonstone inside.

Amber light fell across the joined paper. The old hidden ink shone from the orchard line to the ridge, from the island to the meadow, and all the way back to the crooked root. Every piece belonged to the same path.

Behind the bark, a latch released.

Nib took the handle. The ground-level door swung inward on a broad hinge. Warm, dry air drifted out, carrying the smell of wood and old pages.

Inside stood shelves of illustrated explorer books. A great folding woodland atlas rested on a low table. On a little tray lay a golden acorn, small enough to fit your collection case.

Nib stared at the acorn. Then he looked very carefully around it.

“Is any of the treasure a picnic?” Nib asked with cautious optimism.

Lark laughed softly. She took the moonstone from its lamp cup; the latch stayed released. The stone returned to its traveling compartment. Nib set the acorn in the compartment beside it, where it rested snugly on the soft lining.

Beside the older books was one empty place. A plain cover lay below it.

“There is room for our story,” Lark murmured warmly.

You had nine completed journal pages. Lark added the tenth: the oak from behind, the opened door, and the small golden acorn. She left room beside the drawing for a word that had brought you here.

“Write tap on our last page,” Lark invited gently. “Use the brass flap if you want to check its letters. Three familiar sounds helped us open a very large secret.”

Nib brought the red ribbon from the meadow. Lark laid the ten pages in order and threaded the ribbon through their binding holes. The loose journal became one real book.

On the floor she spread three pictures: the torn map you had first found, the complete map, and the opened room.

“Which picture starts our adventure?” Lark asked softly. “Which belongs in the middle, and which shows how it ended? You can point, put them in order, or tell the story.”

Nib studied the picture of the torn map.

“It looked less promising on my nose,” Nib remembered thoughtfully.

Lark read a little of your new book aloud, leaving map and sat for you to join if you wished. Then she placed The Map Pieces beside the earlier explorers' books. It could be borrowed whenever you wanted to read it again.

The golden acorn stayed in your case. The completed map stayed complete. Your moonstone was ready to travel, and the library door remained open.

Nib settled his sandwich beside the case, carefully outside its treasure compartments.

“And a very small picnic,” Nib murmured contentedly.

Beyond the doorway, evening lay golden around the familiar oak. The atlas held paths for another day. Today, the lost map was whole, the Treasure Tree was found, and your first adventure had its ending.